

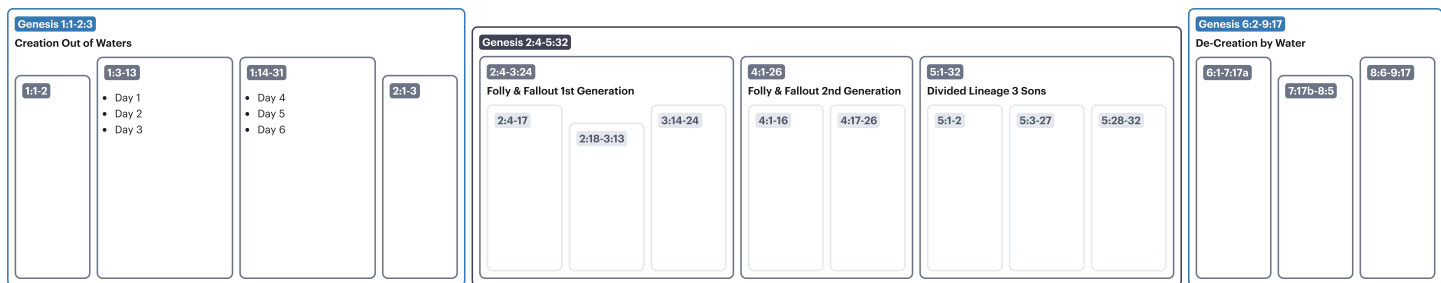
Session 3: The Literary Design of Genesis 1-11

Key Takeaways

- The story in Genesis 1-11 walks us through a thematic cycle of creation, escalating failures, de-creation, and finally the re-creation of a remnant that is commissioned as the new humanity.
- The story of Avraham is designed with multiple movements that repeat and develop this cycle.
- Knowing where you are in the cycle illuminates many of the unique features in the order and design of the Avraham story.

The Thematic Melody of the TaNaK

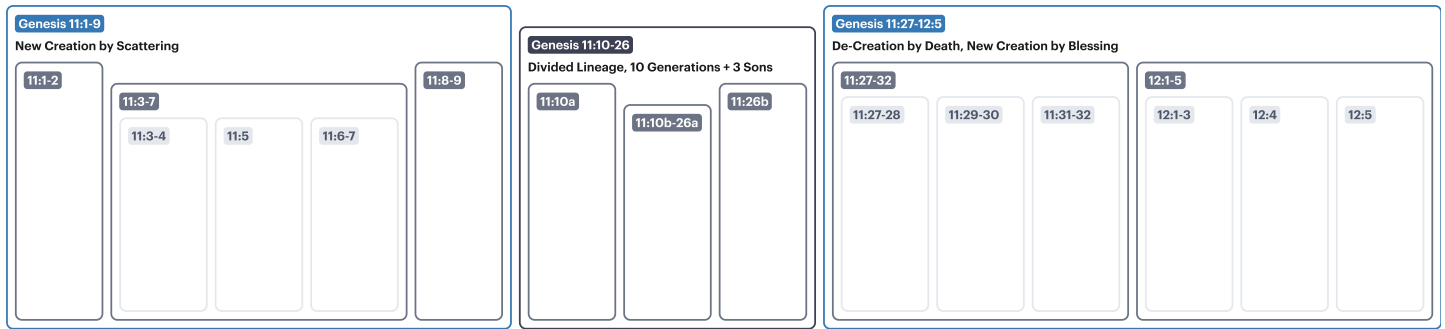
The literary organization of Genesis 1:1-11:26, both in its design and the main themes explored in the narratives, forms the organizational template of the TaNaK. So to truly grasp what the entire TaNaK is about, we need to recap the story so far as it's presented in Genesis 1-11 (adapted from D.A. Teeter, personal communication and his “Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors” paper delivered at the 2019 International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament congress).



Genesis 1:1-9:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 6:1-11:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 11:1-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These thematic cycles set up a narrative pattern and thematic melody that recycles, develops, and advances with each new generation. The basic melody goes like this.

1. Creation and Blessing

- God brings order/life/blessing out of chaos/waters/death/curse.
- Key words: life, blessing, create, establish, seed, sprout, grow, fruit, fruitful and multiply. Also seven, fullness, and oath (all spelled שבע).
- Key images: dry land, refuge, safety, order.

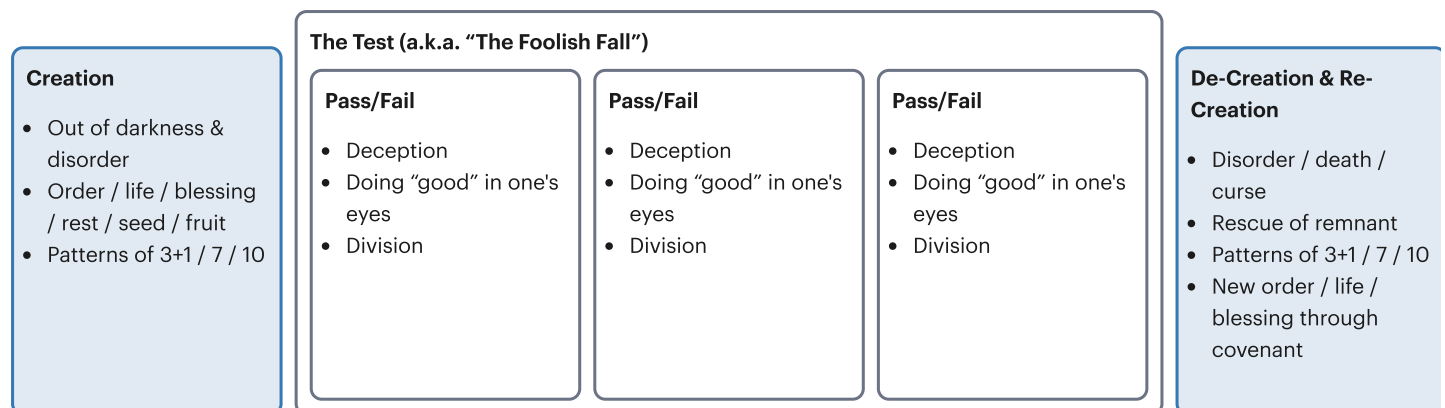
2. Folly, Test, and Failure (a.k.a. “the foolish fall”)

- God invites a chosen human partner to share in the order/life/blessing, which places a decision/test of their trustworthiness on the table.
- God’s chosen partner fails/succeeds the test, usually involving deception/division/violence.
- The same person/next generation faces their own opportunity and test and fails/succeeds, usually involving an intensified expression of deception/division/violence.
- The escalating sequence of tests and failures leads to a separation between the key characters so that one person or family splits off from the rest and is chosen by God for a new future.

3. De-creation and Re-creation

- De-creation: God brings about an inversion of #1 above, usually an escalation of chaos/death/curse.
- Out of that de-creation, God chooses/preserves a remnant/seed and begins a new movement of re-creation through them (often marked by covenants and wordplays on the Hebrew root שבע, “seven/fullness/oath,” or ברית, “covenant”).

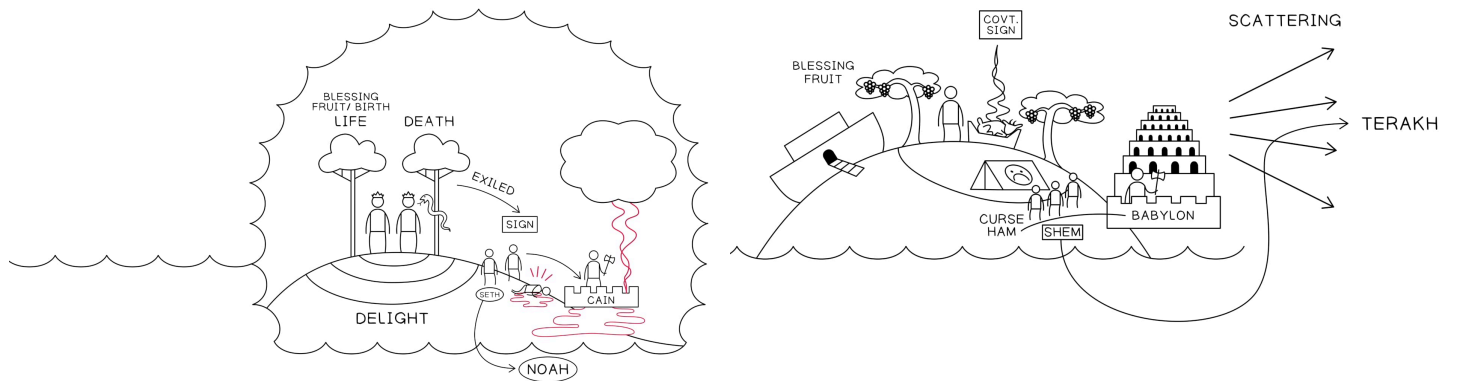
4. Press Repeat



Genesis 1:1-11:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Avraham stories are organized according to this same thematic melody as the cycle replays itself on the macro-level, medium-level, and micro-level of each part of the story.

Genesis 1-11 Thematic Melody Visualized



Genesis 1-11 Thematic Melody. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How do the biblical authors link the Avraham story to the cycle of themes in Genesis 1-11?